STORE MANAGER ESSENTIALS

Store Manager Essentials — Day 3: Build and Coach the Team

Study guide · Self-study

Day 3: Build and Coach the Team

How to Use This Guide

This is Day 3 of a five-day course, and it is yours alone. You work through it at your own pace, with a pen and a quiet half hour. Nobody is watching, and nobody grades you.

Day 1 gave you the manager's stance. You own the result, and you set a few priorities. Day 2 covered the daily operation. Today you build the team that delivers both.

Start by reading each section once. Then go back and do the exercises in "What Would You Say?" Write your answer before you look at the model answers at the end. The models are examples, not scripts. Your words should sound like you.

Every practice task gives you two options. Choose the one that fits you. If you manage a store now, use your real team and your real week. If you are not a store manager yet, use your current shift, section or till area, or the fictional store in this guide, and use the skill to answer a store manager interview question.

Do not use real names, customer details or personal data in any exercise. Describe people by role: "the new hire on the late shift", "the supervisor". Keep it that way throughout.

The Key Takeaways section is your summary of the day. Read it last, then take the Quiz, then finish with the Upskill Challenge.

Today's Objectives (KASU)

Knowledge: You will know how to write an expectation as one observable behavior, how to give each area one owner, and how to give feedback with SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact), which has three parts: the specific Situation, the observable Behavior, and the Impact.

Attitude: You will see coaching as something that happens in short, frequent loops, not as an annual event or a difficult conversation you save up.

Skill: You will be able to run a short coaching loop: name one behavior, give SBI feedback, practice the behavior right away, and agree a check date.

Upskill: You will be able to coach a strong performer, address underperformance early and fairly, and settle friction between two team members without taking sides.

Expectations You Can See and Check

On Day 1 you learned to set priorities with a measurable goal, a named owner and a check date. On Day 2 you learned to write standards that hold on a bad day. Today you make both of those work through people.

The first step is to write expectations as observable behaviors. An observable behavior is something you could see or hear yourself if you stood on the shop floor. "Be more helpful" is not observable. "Greet every walk-in within ten seconds" is. "Take ownership of the stock room" is not observable. "Clear the delivery cart before the first break, and put the empty cart back by the door" is.

Write it as a behavior, and three things happen. You can see whether it happened. The team member can see it too, without guessing what you meant. And feedback becomes a conversation about an action, not about a personality.

There is a psychological reason this matters so much. A vague expectation like "show some initiative" puts the team member in a permanent state of uncertainty, because they never know if they have met it. That uncertainty feels like risk, and people protect themselves against risk by doing less, not more. A clear behavior removes the guessing. It also makes it easier to process, and information that is easy to process feels more familiar and more credible to the person hearing it (Alter & Oppenheimer, 2009), which is why a plain, specific expectation lands and a vague one slides away.

So write each expectation in this shape: the action, when it happens, and what it looks like when it is done well. Then give each area one owner. One area, one name. If two people own the stock room, nobody owns the stock room. That is not a personality flaw, it is a basic feature of how people share responsibility: when no single person is answerable, each person assumes the other is watching.

Practice example: A fictional store's delivery reception area has two people marked as "responsible". Over one fictional month, 40 delivery crates are checked in, and 9 of them sit unprocessed for more than a day. The manager gives the area one owner, one clear behavior (every crate checked and shelved before the shift ends), and one check date. This is a fictional example, not a benchmark.

Write down three expectations for your team now, each as one observable behavior.

Onboarding into the Real Standard

A new hire learns the real standard from two places: what you tell them, and what they see in their first week. If those two things differ, they will copy what they see. That is not laziness. People new to a group look for what actually gets rewarded and what actually happens, because that is the safest way to fit in. Tell a new hire the standard is a tidy till area, and let them watch a busy Saturday with a messy till area and no comment, and the messy version becomes the standard.

So onboarding is not a briefing document. It is a short sequence you run yourself. First, tell the new hire the few behaviors that matter most, in plain words. Second, show them, once, slowly. Third, have them do it while you watch. Fourth, tell them one thing they did well and one thing to change. Fifth, agree a date to check again.

Keep it to a handful of behaviors in the first days. New hires are already taking in a lot, and a long list of standards gets remembered as a blur. A few behaviors practiced until they are automatic will hold when the store is busy and nobody is watching.

If you are not a store manager yet, you can do this with a new starter on your shift, even if you are not their manager. Show them one behavior in your area, let them practice it, and tell your supervisor what you did.

If you are preparing for interviews, expect a question like "How would you onboard a new team member into your standards?" A strong answer names the behaviors, the show-and-practice step, and the check date.

SBI: Feedback That Can Be Heard

SBI (Center for Creative Leadership) is short for Situation, Behavior, Impact. It is a feedback model from the Center for Creative Leadership, and it has three parts only.

Situation: name specifically when and where. "This morning, at the till, just after opening."

Behavior: describe exactly what you saw or heard. Not what you assume was behind it. "You counted the cash drawer twice before unlocking the door."

Impact: say what it did, on the work, the team or the customer. "It kept the first customer waiting about a minute, and she looked around twice before you called her over."

That is the whole model. Three parts, in that order, no verdict, no personality label. Notice what SBI leaves out: "you are careless", "you always do this", "other people manage fine". Those lines feel like feedback to the person saying them, and like an attack to the person hearing them.

Why does the structure work? When a person hears a general criticism, their mind jumps to defending themselves, because the criticism seems to be about who they are. A specific situation and an observable behavior give the brain something concrete to work with, and concrete facts are far harder to argue with than a judgment. The impact part does the rest. Once the person can see the effect of the action on someone or something they care about, the reason to change comes from the effect, not from your authority.

There is a second effect at work. Naming a feeling tends to calm it (Lieberman et al., 2007). If the team member is upset, or you are, a short plain sentence about it ("I could see that frustrated you") usually lowers the temperature enough for the facts to land. That is not part of SBI, it is something you may say before or after it.

Keep the Situation recent. Keep the Behavior to one thing. Keep the Impact real, described in terms of the work.

Practice example: A fictional manager says, "Situation: Saturday, the collection counter. Behavior: you told the customer the order was not ready before checking the shelf. Impact: the order was on the shelf, and the customer came back twice to ask again." This is a fictional example.

Watch out for two common mistakes. The first is smuggling a judgment into the Behavior ("you were a bit dismissive"). The second is stacking three behaviors into one SBI. One behavior at a time, always.

The Coaching Loop and Deliberate Practice

SBI is the feedback. The coaching loop is what you do around it.

The loop has five steps. Observe the real behavior on the floor. Pick one behavior to work on, not three. Give SBI feedback on that one behavior. Practice it right away, in the moment or soon after, while the memory is fresh. Agree a check date and follow up on it.

The practice step is the one most managers skip, and it is the one that makes the loop work. Thinking about a behavior changes very little. Doing the behavior changes a great deal. Research on deliberate practice, starting with Ericsson and colleagues (Ericsson et al., 1993), describes how people improve when they work on one specific skill, get immediate feedback on it, and repeat it.

Later analysis by Macnamara and colleagues (Macnamara et al., 2014) showed that practice explains only part of the difference in performance, so practice is powerful but not the whole story. What that means for you is simple and useful: practice is still the most reliable lever you have, and one focused repetition beats a long general conversation.

So when you give SBI feedback, do not stop there. Ask the team member to do the thing again, now, with you watching. "Let's do it again. When the next customer gets to the counter, check the screen, then greet them."

One behavior, one practice, one check date. Then move on to something else.

If you are not a store manager yet, you can run this loop on yourself, or with a colleague who asks for help. Choose one behavior from your own shift, watch it for a day, then practice it and check it again.

The instincts to fight here are all common. The first is saving feedback for a monthly meeting. The second is giving a team member a list of improvements at once. Both feel thorough. Both are the opposite of effective.

Coaching Strong Performers

The people who already do the job well are the ones most managers stop coaching. That is a costly mistake, for two reasons.

First, strong performers grow bored and leave when nobody invests in them. Second, they set the standard the rest of the team copies, so small gains with them spread further than large gains with anyone else.

Start by asking how a result was achieved before you praise it. If your best seller had a strong week, ask what they did differently. You may find it was a particular greeting, a habit at the till, or a way of handling returns. Once you know how, you can spread it. If you only praise the number, you learn nothing, and the person hears empty words.

Then coach them as you would anyone else: one behavior at a time, specific feedback, a practice step, a check date. Strong performers usually want the next challenge, so choose a behavior that stretches them, not one they already own.

Practice example: A fictional supervisor with the highest add-on rate in the store explains that she asks one question at the till ("Is there anything you need for the weekend?"). The manager watches her do it, then coaches two newer staff through the same one behavior, with a practice round and a check date. This is a fictional example.

Underperformance: Early, Fair, and One Behavior at a Time

Underperformance is easiest to fix early. Left alone, it hardens: the person settles into the habit and the team decides it is tolerated. And because negative experiences tend to weigh more heavily than positive ones (Baumeister et al., 2001), one person consistently not meeting a standard can strain how the whole team feels about the job.

Act early and fairly, and keep it small. Name the standard, give SBI feedback on one example, ask what is getting in the way, practice the behavior, and set a check date. Often the cause is something you can fix: an unclear expectation, a gap in training, a shift pattern that does not fit, or a problem at home the person will share if you ask plainly.

Say what happens next, in plain words. "Let's check this again on Friday." Then keep the check date. Respect and follow your organization's own policy at every step. Formal procedures, warnings and records are set by your organization, not by this guide.

If you are not a store manager yet, you can handle this for an area you supervise, within your authority, or talk it through with your own manager first. Practicing the words out loud matters: write the first two sentences of the conversation, then say them aloud.

If you are preparing for an interview, a question like "How do you handle a team member who is not meeting standards?" is common. A strong answer: early, specific, fair, one behavior at a time, with a check date, and the organization's process followed.

When Two Team Members Fall Out

Friction between two people is not automatically a discipline matter. Very often it is a standards matter wearing a costume: two people disagreeing about how a task should be done, or who owns an area, or what happens when one arrives late.

Do not take sides before you have the facts. Speak to each person on their own. Ask what happened, in specifics, and what they think should happen next. Then look for the standard underneath the argument and fix it: one owner for the area, one behavior everyone follows, one check date.

There is one rule you do hold firmly, whatever the cause: how people speak to each other. Name that standard plainly to both. It is the only ground rule you bring to the conversation, and you apply it to both people equally.

If the friction continues after a clear standard and a check date, it becomes a topic for your manager and the organization's own process.

Apply It in Your Role

If you manage a store now, do these this week:

- ☐ Write three expectations as observable behaviors, one per line, each with a check date.
- ☐ Give every area one named owner, and remove the extra names.
- ☐ Run one coaching loop on the floor: observe, one behavior, SBI, practice it now, check date.
- ☐ Onboard one behavior for any new hire, with a practice round.
- ☐ Have one short conversation with a strong performer about how they got a good result.

If you are not a store manager yet, do these this week:

- ☐ Write three observable behaviors for your own shift or section.
- ☐ Run one coaching loop on yourself: pick a behavior, practice it, check it the next day.

☐ Write the first two sentences of an SBI conversation you would have as a manager, and say them aloud.

☐ Answer aloud, in two minutes: "How would you onboard a new team member into your standards?" Use the show-and-practice step and a check date.

What Would You Say?

Complete each exercise below. Write your answer before you look at the model answers. Then compare: what did yours do well, and what would you change?

Exercise 1: A new hire on the late shift has been leaving the till area untidy at close. Not a serious issue, but it is becoming the standard for the shift.

Exercise 2: Your best seller has the highest add-on rate in the store. You want to learn how she does it and spread it to the rest of the team.

Exercise 3: A team member has missed the stock room behavior four Saturdays in a row. You have mentioned it twice, in passing.

Exercise 4: Two team members on the same shift keep exchanging sharp comments. Both say they are fine.

Key Takeaways

- An expectation you cannot see is a guessing game. Write it as one observable behavior, with a check date.
- One area, one owner. Two names on an area usually means no one owns it.
- A new hire learns the standard from what they see in the first week, not from what you tell them. Show it, let them practice it.
- SBI (Situation, Behavior, Impact) has three parts only: the specific situation, the observable behavior, the impact. No labels, no verdict.
- The coaching loop is SBI plus a practice step plus a check date. One behavior at a time.
- Ask how a strong performer got a result before you praise it, then coach the behavior behind it.
- Address underperformance early and fairly, in one-behavior steps, and follow your organization's own policy for formal steps.
- Friction between people is often a standards problem wearing a costume. Fix the standard and name one ground rule: how people speak to each other.

Quiz

Answer all five questions. Write your answers down before you read the answers in the Model Answers section.

Upskill Challenge

This is your on-the-job challenge for Day 3. Do it before Day 4.

If you manage a store now:

Field assignment: Run one full coaching loop with one team member, within the next three days. Observe one behavior, give SBI feedback on one example, practice it right away, and set a check date. Keep it to ten minutes.

Team huddle: At your next team huddle, read out one expectation, rewritten as an observable behavior, and ask the team to say what it would look like on a bad Saturday.

Written assignment: Write one page containing four things: (1) three expectations as observable behaviors, (2) the owner of each area you reviewed and the owner you removed, (3) your SBI loop, written as you said it, and (4) what the team member did differently in the practice step. Share the page with your manager at your next check-in.

If you are not a store manager yet:

Field assignment: Run one coaching loop on yourself this week. Pick one behavior in your own shift or section, watch it for a day, practice it, and check it the next day. Write down what changed.

Role-play: Partner with a friend. Ask them to play a team member who has left the till area untidy three times. Give SBI feedback, then ask them to practice the correct behavior. Swap roles.

Written assignment: Write one page for a store manager interview. Answer this question in your own words: "How would you build a team that meets standards on a bad day?" Cover observable behaviors, one owner per area, the show-and-practice step in onboarding, and one short coaching loop. Keep it to one page, and read it aloud before you save it.

Model Answers

These are examples, not scripts. What matters is the principle behind each answer.

Exercise 1. "Situation: close of the late shift, last night. Behavior: the till area was left with the float uncounted and the bags on the counter. Impact: the morning team spent the first ten minutes tidying and counting before opening, and they had to serve the first customer late. Let's practice the close now: what's step one, step two, step three? Let's check the close together again on Thursday." Why it works: a specific situation, an observable behavior, a real impact on other people, then practice on the spot and a check date.

Exercise 2. "Your add-on rate is the highest in the store. What are you doing at the till that others are missing? Can I watch your next five customers and write down what you say? I want to teach that one behavior to the rest of the team." Why it works: asking how first, learning the actual behavior, then spreading one behavior rather than praising a number.

Exercise 3. "Situation: the last four Saturdays. Behavior: the stock room behavior we agreed, closing every cart before the end of the shift, was missed again. Impact: the Monday morning team starts behind. I should have stopped this in week one. What's in the way, and what would make it work? Let's check it together next Saturday." Why it works: it names the missed behavior honestly, owns the delay in the manager's own response, asks what the cause is, and sets a check date.

Exercise 4. "You've both said you're fine, but I've heard the sharp comments, and I've seen the effect on the shift. You both do this job well, and the loudest thing I hear is that something about how the work is done is not clear. Let's look at the standard for this area together. One rule I hold: how you speak to each other. What do you each see as the problem?" Why it works: it stays off sides, looks for the standard underneath, names one ground rule for both people, and asks rather than accuses.

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